

Staff Days — Week 2, Day 6 (Mon Aug 3)

Format note: Week 2 breaks the Week 1 shape. Everyone is back at their home campuses and this is a ~50-minute network open led by Steph, not a full day of general session. Joe doesn't appear. There's no post-lunch tee-up on the recording — the afternoon was campus build time. What follows is the whole recorded session.

Week 2 structure

0:00–0:04

Week 1 was the 10,000-foot view. **Week 2 is tactical build**, focused on guides, producing every piece needed to execute at standard on day one. Calendar A starts in 9 days.

Daily rhythm for the week:

- Network open, brief
- **11am Central — one hour on Guide Platform**, every day. Get in, test workflows, give feedback to Alec
- Lunch — tentative app demos and lunch-and-learns
- Network close together, then keep working if your campus needs to

Why the app demos are tentative: Joe still has to approve the brain lifts behind the apps. Until he does, academics and the consumer builders can't present them.

The rest of the week is campus and level groups building launches, boot camp routines and check charts, workshops, and how town hall and closings run for the first eight weeks — locking in fundamentals before the bangers.

Michelle, the new head of people, introduced herself and is booking **individual time with every guide before school starts**. Her approach is listen before act: what's working, what isn't, what to replicate, what's around the corner. Watch for invites; ping her on Slack if you're off-site or the time doesn't work.

Closing the loop on Find Your Feathers

0:06–0:35

Guides did this exercise in June and re-ran it Friday so new guides could learn the process. Steph pulled all the June outputs, had AI aggregate them into a network-wide summary doc, and the job today was **human QC on the AI's output** — do we agree with the takeaways, disagree anywhere, is anything missing, does anything need deleting. "AI cannot drive."

Two buckets. Things outside guide control (fixing Alpha Read, app-level problems) go to Andy Montgomery, academics, and the super builders, who own those fixes and have been doing their own feathers work over the summer. The debrief focused on **controllables** — things that could be running by next Wednesday.

Every fix the network agrees on becomes Alpha Canon — spun up as a work unit, with Tier 1 canon, Tier 2 level/model variance, and Tier 3 guide magic defined. Audri is building a tracker; about 25 work units remain to be written, and lead guides will divvy up the writing.

The fixes that surfaced

Early flagging. The top-voted one: catch lagging students in Session 2 rather than discovering in Session 5 that a kid has to do writing over spring break. The "doom loop" example was a student stuck on fluency and not progressing in reading — the guide flagged it verbally, but raw data would have caught it network-wide. **Guide Platform lets campuses build their own triggers**, so a proposed rule is: when a student's XP falls below the pace required to hit 2X by year end, auto-flag and force an adjustment.

Mid-year joiners. The single strongest signal across nearly all campuses. Kids starting at the beginning of the year get three days of group onboarding with their guides (Wed–Fri of week 1 for Calendar A) before the boot camp check chart. Mid-year joiners currently get the check chart async with guide support during check-chart time — and nothing else. Proposed additions:

- **A peer buddy**, from Scottsdale. They followed up with kids who marked "no" on feeling safe in town hall and found it wasn't fear — the kid didn't know enough about what was going on to contribute. The buddy sits with them at town hall, explains XP and the behavior model, and covers when to speak up. Roughly two weeks, longer for younger levels, shorter for L2 and middle school to protect independence.
- **An onboarding checklist** of the DOK1 Alpha basics you can't assume a new kid knows — what the three commitments are, what an alpha test is.
- **Miami's ambassador model**: an elected ambassador walks new students through town hall and makes them speak up their very first time, so they learn that a rejected idea gets a respectful "here's why" rather than ostracism. Miami middle school also runs **Flawless Coins** — 14 blocks a day, students self-assess whether each block met cultural standards. Culture gets enforced by students, not because a guide said so.
- **Palm Beach on growth**: when a campus scales (they went 4 → 10), preserving culture matters most. Give existing Alpha-trained students leadership roles to teach new kids the language and attitude, so it isn't all on guides.

Shadow days. Add a **socialization check to the check chart** for the student buddy — the shadow kid confirms at day's end that their buddy actually made them welcome, didn't leave them alone more than 5–10 minutes, ate with them, and introduced them around. Logistics confirmed there's enough shadow volume for this not to bottleneck anyone. Flagged as canon-worthy on the spot.

Trips and experiences. Middle school raised that trips were gated on a single test-to-pass, so kids who failed felt disenfranchised — and it cost love of school. Proposal: a **multi-tiered unlock, three of four** — academic goals, behavior, workshop engagement (a weekly survey guides QC), and check chart progress. The counterpoint that landed: the problem isn't that unlocks are too hard, it's that support and scaffolding are too thin. Keep the bar high, raise the support.

Separately, **experiences are getting more rigorous this year** under Taylor. Not field trips, not tourist traps, not celebrations — kids do real life-skill work tied to what's being measured, with meaningful unlocks. Trips, especially international ones, are the highest-currency motivator guides have. The classic lever named: **be at grade level**. Kids arriving two or three grade levels behind close that gap remarkably fast when Italy is on the line.

Life skills workshops. Two themes:

1. **Track skill acquisition** through the workshop, not just at the end. Baseline plus Checkpoint 1 and 2 helped in Sessions 3–5; the new builder has a more fleshed-out version. TSA added that **sub-skills** rather than one skill per workshop makes it more usable for kids and coaches.
2. **Simulate the alpha test pressure beforehand.** Scottsdale suggested running the test-to-pass on day one where possible — an alpha pre-test — because kids could often perform with prompting but failed doing it independently.

Also: be explicit with students about what the life skill actually is. Show the rubric day one and repeat the language in different contexts, because it's easy for kids to get lost in the cheese — "I'm doing this LEGO thing" without knowing they're being assessed on iteration. **The standard set:** any visitor walking through during workshop time should be able to ask any kid the name of the workshop, the life skill, and the alpha test, and get an answer immediately.

Naming changes: "alpha test" now splits into **academic alpha test** and **life skill alpha test**. Check-to-Pass docs are now **Alpha Check docs**.

Guide Platform

0:35–0:44

One place to work — five tabs instead of fifty. **Everything you enter is tagged to a kid and enriches that kid's profile**, so any guide who picks them up later can motivate them from day one instead of playing knowledge telephone across a link dump of spreadsheets. This is the direct answer to Friday's guide-transition feather.

It houses launches, town halls, PR/360, workshops, baseline/checkpoint/alpha test, check charts, lunches, limitless meetings, the behavioral model, and motivational models. When a kid gets a yellow card, red card, or strike, the data lands there, the DOP is notified, and the loop closes when they confirm they've spoken to parents.

On the AI review: it's framed as **feedback, not QC**. It's built on Steph's written quality standards, it isn't gospel, and it isn't a grade to chase. There should always be a way to **disagree with the AI** — those disagreements go back to Steph and Alec to tune it, or to start a conversation about why.

Cadence for the three commitments data capture isn't set yet — it won't be the daily per-kid-per-commitment intensity of Alpha Summer, but it's built into the system.

Alec is the only developer on it and lands in Austin tonight. He sent an async walkthrough doc in the Pre-K guide channel that names what to ignore for now. **Worth getting in even if you used it all summer** — it's been majorly revamped.

Tomorrow

0:46–0:50

- **Morning: line-by-line review of the new behavior policy.** First time in Alpha's history that all campuses will be aligned on a single behavioral standard, which is why all ~200 guides need to get it. Not a read-through — ask questions and wrestle with it. Guides and lead guides currently in training should try to join.
- Guide Platform with Alec in person.
- **Afternoon: boot camp check charts**, dispersed in pairs to build the actual Alpha Check docs. Head guides have them staged; everyone will have a hand in one or two docs that scale across every school.

North star: the **S1 Guide Deliverables tab** on the staff days agenda and hub. Exemplars are being linked in. Questions go in the guide channel.